



last tak kuch keh nahi sakte (this is cricket, you can't say anything till the end)."

Not that they doubted the team's position, but as former cricketers, Nadeem and Tiwary were unwilling to jump the gun. Over long careers, they had seen too many so-near-yet-so-far moments. This time, with history beckoning, they chose to wait.

In 2017, Jharkhand lost to Bengal in the semifinal of the Vijay Hazare Trophy. Three years later, it went down to the same opponent in the Ranji Trophy quarterfinal.

After years of heartbreak, Ishan Kishan's men finally gave the State reason to celebrate. Jharkhand defeated Haryana convincingly in the final to win 10 of its 11 matches in the tournament. Captain Ishan led from the front, scoring 517 runs at 57.32 and struck at a whopping 197.32. He scored two fifties and two hundreds, including a century in the final against Haryana (101 off 49).

While the players celebrated their

biggest success in recent times, it was also a triumph of the Jharkhand model, rewired at the start of the season by Tiwary and Nadeem, now office-bearers at the JSCA, under the guidance of a man who has seen Jharkhand cricket from its nascent years: Mahendra Singh Dhoni.

No cricket conversation in the State is complete without a mention of the former India captain. His influence on the sport and the younger generation has been enduring, but it was his hands-on involvement ahead of the season that proved invaluable.

As Nadeem told *Sportstar*, "When we started this season, and were selecting the coaches, Dhoni was very much involved in the process. His input was always important."

The Mahi way

Dhoni advised the administrators not to chase big names, but to identify coaches who could be utilised better. Acting on his suggestion, Jharkhand appointed locals Ratan

Final reward: Saurabh Tiwary (left) and Shahbaz Nadeem, secretary and joint secretary of the Jharkhand State Cricket Association, pose with the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy after Jharkhand defeated Haryana in the final. SHAYAN ACHARYA

Kumar as head coach, Sunny Gupta as bowling coach, and the vastly experienced Madhusudan Tantubhai as fielding coach. Ratan had coached the State's U-23 side. "I remember Dhoni telling me that instead of looking for fancy, high-end coaches, our *desi* coaches should be preferred, because they understand the sentiments of our players, their feelings and hence, communication will be better," Nadeem said. "Most of our players come from humble backgrounds, so Dhoni felt that if we bring outsiders, communication will be a major barrier, and that could put the players in a cocoon. But with our local coaches, things were simple, and players could understand exactly